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Topic: Bangladesh in International Affairs

Definition of Foreign Policy

- The foreign policy of a state can be considered as a complex and dynamic political course that it maintains in relation to other states to protect its own national interest. Generally, it is believed that foreign policy is a wheel through which the process of international politics operates. Conceptually, foreign policy is that part of the national policy of a state which relates to the external environment.
- "Foreign policy" according to **Morshed Khan**, Former Foreign Minister of Bangladesh, "is in effect a blue print for our interaction with the rest of the World". **Prince Otto Von Bismark** defined foreign policy as, "the extension of domestic policy." **Henry Kissinger** gave a simplistic definition: "Foreign policy begins where domestic policy ends."
- **Prof. Joseph Frankel** says in his Book 'The Making of Foreign Policy (1993)' that "foreign policy consists of decisions and actions which involve to some appreciable extent relations between one state and others.
- **Padel Ford and Lincoln** have defined foreign policy in these words "a state foreign policy is the totality of its dealings with external environment.
- **Manners and Whiteman** (2000) defined Foreign policy briefly 'as the sum of official external relations conducted by an independent actor (usually a state) in international relations'.

Objectives of Bangladesh Foreign Policy

This document elaborates on the key objectives of Bangladesh's foreign policy, which are essential for the nation's growth and stability. The foreign policy framework is designed to ensure self-preservation, economic advancement, and the safeguarding of national interests while promoting international cooperation and peace. Each objective plays a crucial role in shaping Bangladesh's interactions on the global stage and reflects the country's aspirations for a prosperous future.

1. Self-Preservation

The foremost objective of Bangladesh's foreign policy is self-preservation. This entails protecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the nation against external threats. By maintaining a strong defense and fostering diplomatic relations, Bangladesh aims to create a secure environment for its citizens and safeguard its national interests.

2. Economic Advancement and Integration

Economic advancement is a pivotal goal of Bangladesh's foreign policy. The country seeks to integrate into the global economy by enhancing trade relations, attracting foreign investment, and participating in regional economic initiatives. This objective is vital for achieving sustainable development and improving the living standards of the Bangladeshi people.

3. Safeguarding and Augmenting National Power

Bangladesh aims to safeguard and augment its national power through strategic partnerships and alliances. By strengthening its military capabilities and enhancing its diplomatic influence, the country seeks to assert its position in regional and international affairs, ensuring that its voice is heard on critical issues.

4. Upholding National Ideology and Prestige

Upholding the national ideology and prestige of Bangladesh is another significant objective of its foreign policy. The government strives to promote the values and principles that define the nation, such as democracy, secularism, and social justice.

By projecting a positive image internationally, Bangladesh aims to enhance its standing and influence on the global stage.

5. Building National and International Cooperation

Building both national and international cooperation is essential for addressing global challenges. Bangladesh actively engages in multilateral forums and regional organizations to foster collaboration on issues such as climate change, trade, and security. This cooperative approach is vital for achieving collective goals and promoting mutual understanding.

6. Developing Political Harmonies in the World

Bangladesh's foreign policy also focuses on developing political harmonies in the world. By advocating for dialogue and diplomacy, the country seeks to resolve conflicts peacefully and promote stability in various regions. This objective aligns with Bangladesh's commitment to global peace and security.

7. Ensuring Global Peace

Ensuring global peace is a fundamental goal of Bangladesh's foreign policy. The country actively participates in peacekeeping missions and supports international efforts to prevent conflicts. By contributing to global peace initiatives, Bangladesh demonstrates its commitment to a stable and secure world.

8. Maintenance of Territorial Integrity

The maintenance of territorial integrity is critical for Bangladesh's sovereignty. The government prioritizes border security and territorial defense to prevent encroachments and maintain control over its land and maritime boundaries.

9. Multilateralism

Bangladesh strongly advocates for multilateralism in international relations. The country believes that collaborative approaches are essential for addressing global

challenges, such as climate change, poverty, and health crises. By engaging in multilateral institutions, Bangladesh seeks to amplify its voice and influence global decision-making.

10. Combating Terrorism

Combating terrorism is a priority for Bangladesh's foreign policy. The government collaborates with international partners to address the threat of terrorism and extremism. By promoting counter-terrorism measures and sharing intelligence, Bangladesh aims to ensure the safety and security of its citizens.

11. Increasing Remittances and Intellectual Investment

Increasing remittances and attracting intellectual investment are crucial for Bangladesh's economic growth. The government encourages the Bangladeshi diaspora to invest in their homeland and contribute to national development. By creating a conducive environment for investment, Bangladesh aims to harness the potential of its citizens abroad.

12. Mobilization of International Support for Debt Reduction

Bangladesh seeks to mobilize international support for debt reduction to ensure sustainable economic growth. By engaging with international financial institutions and donor countries, the government aims to alleviate the burden of debt and create a more favorable economic environment.

13. Market Expansion

Market expansion is a vital objective of Bangladesh's foreign policy. The country aims to diversify its export markets and reduce dependency on a limited number of trading partners. By exploring new markets, Bangladesh seeks to enhance its economic resilience and promote sustainable growth.

14. Promotion of Trade

The promotion of trade is central to Bangladesh's economic strategy. The government actively seeks to negotiate trade agreements and enhance trade relations with other countries. By fostering a favorable trade environment, Bangladesh aims to boost its economy and create job opportunities for its citizens.

Key Principles of Bangladesh Foreign Policy

- Every state follows some principles upon which the entire foreign policy revolves. As an active member of the United Nations (UN) and Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), Bangladesh follows the principles enshrined in the UN Charter and the principles of NAM. In fact, Bangladesh's foreign policy has stemmed out of constitutional declaration.
- **Article 25 of the Bangladesh Constitution stated:**

Bangladesh shall base its international relations on the principles of respect for national sovereignty, and equality, non-interference in the internal affairs of other countries, peaceful settlement of international disputes and respect for international law and the principles enunciated in the UN Charter.

- **The key principles of the foreign policy of Bangladesh are:**
 1. Friendship to All, Malice to None [1(2) of UN charter]
 2. Nonintervention in the Internal Matters of Other States [2(7) of UN charter]
 3. Equality and Mutual Benefit
 4. Respect for Sovereignty, Territorial Integrity, and Political Independence of Other States [2(4) of UN charter]
 5. To Ensure International Peace and Security [NPT/UN]
 6. Peaceful Co-Existence

1. Friendship to All, Malice to None

This principle embodies the essence of Bangladesh's diplomatic approach. It emphasizes the importance of maintaining friendly relations with all countries while avoiding hostility or malice towards any nation. This aligns with the spirit of

Article 1(2) of the UN Charter, which promotes friendly relations among nations based on respect for the principle of equal rights and self-determination of peoples.

2. Nonintervention in the Internal Matters of Other States

Bangladesh firmly upholds the principle of nonintervention, as articulated in Article 2(7) of the UN Charter. This principle asserts that no state should interfere in the internal affairs of another state, thereby promoting a respectful and peaceful coexistence among nations. Bangladesh believes that each country has the right to determine its own political, economic, and social systems without external interference.

3. Equality and Mutual Benefit

The foreign policy of Bangladesh is grounded in the belief that all nations are equal, regardless of their size or power. This principle fosters an environment where countries can engage in partnerships and collaborations that are mutually beneficial. Bangladesh advocates for equitable treatment in international relations, ensuring that its interests are respected while also considering the needs and aspirations of other nations.

4. Respect for Sovereignty, Territorial Integrity, and Political Independence of Other States

Respecting the sovereignty and territorial integrity of other nations is a cornerstone of Bangladesh's foreign policy. Article 2(4) of the UN Charter emphasizes the importance of refraining from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any state. Bangladesh's commitment to this principle reinforces its dedication to a stable and peaceful international order.

5. To Ensure International Peace and Security

Bangladesh actively participates in international efforts to maintain peace and security, as outlined in various international treaties, including the Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT). The country recognizes that global stability is

essential for development and prosperity, and it strives to contribute to peacekeeping missions and diplomatic initiatives aimed at conflict resolution.

6. Peaceful Co-Existence

The principle of peaceful coexistence is integral to Bangladesh's foreign policy. It advocates for harmonious relations among nations, promoting dialogue and understanding as means to resolve conflicts. This principle encourages countries to live together in peace, respecting each other's differences and working collaboratively towards common goals.

Determinants of Bangladesh Foreign Policy

This document delves into the various determinants that shape the foreign policy of Bangladesh. Understanding these determinants is crucial for comprehending how Bangladesh navigates its international relations and responds to global challenges. The factors influencing foreign policy are categorized into two broad categories: internal and external. Each category encompasses a range of elements that collectively inform the decisions made by the Bangladeshi government in the international arena.

Internal Factors

a. Size

The size of Bangladesh, both in terms of its territory and population, plays a significant role in its foreign policy. A larger population can lead to greater demands for resources and international support, while the geographic size can influence diplomatic relations and territorial disputes.

b. Geography

Geographical factors such as fertility, climate, and location relative to other land masses and waterways are critical. Bangladesh's position in South Asia, bordered

by India and Myanmar, and its proximity to the Bay of Bengal, affect its trade routes, security concerns, and environmental policies.

c.Culture and History

The rich cultural heritage and historical experiences of Bangladesh shape its national identity and influence its foreign relations. Historical ties with neighboring countries, colonial past, and cultural connections can foster alliances or create tensions.

d.Economic Development

The level of economic development directly impacts Bangladesh's foreign policy. A growing economy may enhance its bargaining power on the international stage, while economic challenges can limit its foreign policy options and necessitate reliance on foreign aid and partnerships.

e.Social Structure

The social structure of Bangladesh, characterized by divisions based on wealth, religion, and regional disparities, can hinder the pursuit of a cohesive foreign policy. A fragmented society may struggle to present a unified stance on international issues.

f.Public Mood

Public sentiment and opinion can significantly influence foreign policy decisions. The government must consider the views of its citizens, especially in a democratic context, where public support is crucial for sustaining foreign initiatives.

g.Technology

Technological advancements play a vital role in shaping foreign policy. Bangladesh's ability to leverage technology for economic growth, security, and communication can enhance its international standing and influence.

h.National Capacity

National capacity encompasses military power, technological advancement, and economic development. A strong national capacity enables Bangladesh to assert its interests more effectively in the global arena.

I. Political Organization, Accountability, and Leadership

The political organization of Bangladesh, including the effectiveness of its governance and the accountability of its leaders, significantly impacts foreign policy. Strong leadership can drive proactive foreign initiatives, while political instability may lead to reactive or inconsistent policies.

j. Role of Press and Media

The press and media serve as critical platforms for public discourse and can shape perceptions of foreign policy. A free and responsible media can foster informed public debate, while state-controlled media may limit transparency and accountability in foreign affairs.

External Factors

a. Power Structure

The geopolitical landscape and power dynamics in South Asia and beyond are crucial external factors influencing Bangladesh's foreign policy. The relationships with neighboring countries, particularly India and China, and the broader international power structure dictate strategic decisions.

b. International Organizations

Participation in international organizations such as the United Nations (UN), Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC), Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation (BIMSTEC), World Bank (WB), and Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) provides Bangladesh with platforms for collaboration and influence. These organizations

can help address regional issues, economic development, and humanitarian concerns.

In conclusion, the foreign policy of Bangladesh is shaped by a complex interplay of internal and external factors. Understanding these determinants provides insight into how Bangladesh navigates its international relations and responds to global challenges.

Outcome of Bangladesh foreign policy in different era

1. The Success of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman: Bangladesh's Foreign Policy (1972-75)

This document explores the significant outcomes of Bangladesh's foreign policy during the era of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman from 1972 to 1975. It highlights key achievements that laid the foundation for the newly independent nation's international relations, including the withdrawal of Indian troops, water-sharing agreements, participation in international organizations, and the quest for global recognition. The analysis underscores how these diplomatic efforts shaped Bangladesh's identity on the world stage.

a. Withdrawal of Indian Troops from Bangladesh

One of the foremost achievements of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's foreign policy was the successful negotiation for the withdrawal of Indian troops stationed in Bangladesh following the Liberation War. The presence of Indian forces was a sensitive issue for the nascent government, and their withdrawal was crucial for establishing Bangladesh's sovereignty. The completion of this withdrawal in March 1974 marked a significant step towards national independence and self-determination.

b. Water Sharing Agreement with India

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman adeptly utilized his relationship with Indian Prime Minister Indira Gandhi to negotiate a reasonable share of the Ganges water. This was a critical issue for Bangladesh, as the Ganges River is vital for agriculture and

livelihoods in the region. The agreement not only showcased Rahman's diplomatic skills but also highlighted the importance of regional cooperation in managing shared water resources.

c. Participation in the OIC Conference and Tripartite Agreement

Bangladesh's participation in the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) conference in Lahore in 1974 was another significant milestone. This involvement helped to strengthen Bangladesh's ties with Muslim countries and positioned it as a key player in the Islamic world. Additionally, the tripartite agreement of 1974 involving India, Bangladesh, and Pakistan was a landmark achievement. It facilitated the granting of "clemency" to the 195 Pakistani prisoners of war held in India, reflecting a spirit of reconciliation and the desire to move beyond the conflicts of the past.

C. Diplomatic Engagement with the United States and Non-Aligned Movement

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman also made strides in establishing diplomatic relations with the United States and sought membership in the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM). His visit to Washington was a pivotal moment that underscored Bangladesh's intention to engage with major global powers while maintaining an independent foreign policy. This approach allowed Bangladesh to navigate the complexities of Cold War politics and assert its position on the international stage.

d. Global Recognition of Bangladesh

During this formative phase, Bangladesh achieved recognition from a large number of countries, including Pakistan, various Western nations, and members of the Non-Aligned and Muslim blocs. This recognition was crucial for Bangladesh's legitimacy as a sovereign state and facilitated its participation in international forums. The government's serious initiatives to seek recognition from China and Saudi Arabia further exemplified its commitment to building a diverse network of diplomatic relationships.

e. Entry into the United Nations

One of the crowning achievements of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's foreign policy was Bangladesh's entry into the United Nations. Gaining UN membership in 1974 was a significant milestone that not only affirmed Bangladesh's status as an independent nation but also provided a platform for voicing its concerns and aspirations on a global scale.

2. The Success of Ziaur Rahman (1975-1981)

- A. The principal achievements of the period were consolidation and strengthening of the relationship with China through widening and deepening of cooperation.
- B. Positive initiatives for resolution of outstanding issues with India particularly during the time of Prime Minister Moraji Desai.
- C. Formation of SAARC by enlisting the support of South Asian countries.
- D. The other diplomatic achievement of Ziaur Rahman was the election of Bangladesh as a non-permanent member of the UN Security Council.

3. The Success of H M Ershad (1981-1990)

- E. The foreign policy under Ershad did not significantly deviate from what it was under Ziaur Rahman.
- F. Ershad declared Islam the state of the religion
- G. The regional organization: SAARC was formally formed in the time of Ershad.
- H. Bangladesh Army started to work in the UN Peacekeeping Mission. The

3. The Success of Khaleda Zia (1991-1996)

- A. In the wave of globalization and privatization, Bangladesh moved towards enhancing trade and investment for economic development.
- B. The policymakers of Bangladesh would come closer to India for regional and bilateral economic cooperation.

- C. India handed over the Tin Bigha Corridor on a lease and opened it for use by Bangladeshi passengers and vehicular traffic in 1992.

4. The Success of Sheikh Hasina (1996-2001)

- A. Landmark treaty on sharing of the Ganga water with India.
- B. The signing of a historic agreement with Shanti Bahini in CHT.
- C. India and Bangladesh started to liberalize at a rapid pace with the deficit in formal trade rising.

5. The Success of Khaleda Zia (2001-2006)

- A. Look East Policy
- B. Strong Relations with OIC countries and China
- C. Transit, Transshipment and Gas Pipeline

6. Recent Achievements (2008 – up to present)

- A. The Maritime Boundary dispute between Bangladesh and Myanmar settled in 2012 and Bangladesh got the victory.
- B. Delimitation of the Maritime Boundary between Bangladesh and India in 2014.
- C. Bangladesh-India Land Boundary Agreement (LBA) passed in the Indian parliament and executed by long-discussed enclave problems solved in Bangladesh and India.
- D. Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina received the South-South Award, Champion of the Earth, and many International awards.
- E. Bangladesh is playing an active role in many international organizations.
- F. Bangladesh successfully controlled terrorism activities.
- G. Increase in migration and remittance in recent times.
- H. Economic Aid and Cooperation from China, Japan, the World Bank, and India have increased.
- I. The Bangabandhu Satellite-1, 1st Bangladeshi geostationary communications and Broadcasting Satellite, launched in 2018.

Challenges for Bangladesh Foreign Policy

This document explores the multifaceted challenges facing Bangladesh's foreign policy, particularly in the context of the Rohingya crisis, climate change, and various socio-political issues. As Bangladesh navigates its international relations, it must address these pressing concerns to foster a stable and prosperous future.

a. Rohingya Crisis

The Rohingya crisis remains a significant challenge for Bangladesh's foreign policy. The influx of Rohingya refugees from Myanmar has created humanitarian, economic, and security concerns. The repatriation of these individuals has become a matter of great concern, as Bangladesh grapples with the complexities of ensuring their safety and dignity while also managing its own resources. The lack of a sustainable solution to this crisis puts immense pressure on Bangladesh's diplomatic relations, particularly with Myanmar and other neighboring countries.

b. Climate Change Problem

Bangladesh is one of the countries most vulnerable to the impacts of climate change and global warming. Rising sea levels, increased frequency of natural disasters, and changing weather patterns threaten the livelihoods of millions. This environmental crisis poses a significant challenge for Bangladesh's foreign policy as it seeks international support and cooperation to combat climate change. The need for climate adaptation and mitigation strategies is critical, and Bangladesh must advocate for equitable global policies that address the needs of developing nations.

c. Rise in Religious Intolerance

The rise in religious intolerance within Bangladesh poses a threat to its social fabric and international image. This intolerance can lead to internal strife and complicate diplomatic relations with countries that prioritize human rights and religious freedom. Bangladesh's foreign policy must address these issues to maintain its standing in the international community and foster peaceful coexistence among its diverse population.

d. Development of Extremism

The development of extremism in Bangladesh is another challenge that impacts its foreign policy. The rise of radical ideologies can destabilize the nation and create security concerns that affect regional stability. Bangladesh must work to counteract extremism through effective domestic policies while also seeking international cooperation to address the root causes of radicalization.

e. Shortage of Foreign Diplomatic Missions Abroad

A shortage of foreign diplomatic missions limits Bangladesh's ability to engage effectively with the global community. This lack of representation can hinder trade, investment, and diplomatic relations, making it difficult for Bangladesh to advocate for its interests on the international stage. Expanding its diplomatic presence is essential for Bangladesh to enhance its foreign policy capabilities.

f. Inexperienced and Reactive Diplomats

The presence of inexperienced and reactive diplomats can undermine Bangladesh's foreign policy effectiveness. Investing in training and development for diplomats is crucial for building a competent foreign service that can navigate complex global issues.

g. Patronizing Corruption

Corruption remains a significant obstacle to Bangladesh's foreign policy objectives. Patronizing corruption can erode trust in government institutions and deter foreign investment. Addressing corruption is vital for creating a conducive environment for international partnerships and enhancing Bangladesh's global standing.

h. Political Intolerance and Mudslinging

Political intolerance and mudslinging within Bangladesh can create instability and hinder effective governance. This internal discord can negatively impact foreign

relations, as external partners may be hesitant to engage with a politically fractured nation. Promoting political dialogue and cooperation is essential for strengthening Bangladesh's foreign policy.

i. Absence of Coordination and Cooperation

The absence of coordination and cooperation among various government agencies can lead to fragmented foreign policy efforts. A cohesive approach is necessary to address the complex challenges facing Bangladesh and to present a united front in international negotiations.

j. Critical Relationships Between India and Bangladesh

The relationship between India and Bangladesh is critical for regional stability and development. However, historical tensions and current disputes can complicate diplomatic efforts. Bangladesh must navigate these challenges carefully to foster a constructive partnership with India while addressing its own national interests.

k. Inequitable Distribution of Resources

Inequitable distribution of resources within Bangladesh can lead to social unrest and hinder development efforts. This internal disparity can also affect foreign policy, as marginalized communities may feel excluded from the benefits of international engagement. Ensuring equitable resource distribution is essential for fostering social cohesion and stability.

l. Mistrust and Misunderstandings

Mistrust and misunderstandings between Bangladesh and other nations can complicate diplomatic relations. Building trust through transparent communication and engagement is vital for overcoming these barriers and fostering productive international partnerships.

m. One-Way Foreign Trade and Investment

Bangladesh's foreign trade and investment landscape has often been characterized as one-sided, with limited reciprocal benefits. This imbalance can hinder economic growth and development. Bangladesh must work to create a more equitable trade environment that encourages mutual investment and benefits for all parties involved.

In conclusion, Bangladesh faces numerous challenges in its foreign policy that require strategic planning and international cooperation. Addressing these issues is essential for promoting national interests and ensuring a stable and prosperous future for the country.